



Coder Barbie

After half a million votes were cast to decide Barbie's newest career, kids now have Computer Engineer Barbie as their newest companion



Veronica Belmont

A self confessed geeky chick, has 16 lakh followers on Twitter

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The image of a sweaty Megan Fox reaching under the hood of a Chevy Camaro in Transformers is imprinted in all our geek minds. The reason for this indelible memory is not just the obvious - it's Megan Fox - but it's more to do with the fact that she's doing something that is traditionally believed be a man's domain and at the same time, she's damn good at it. At the risk of sounding like a chauvinist - what is it with women who do things that are unconventional that's so err engaging?

But before your testosterone fuelled mind starts getting any ideas, we must say - down boys! What we're going to be talking about in this story is women who are busy conquering new lands in kingdom of geekdom. The image you're looking for is more of Sandra Bullock in The Net.

Identifying the geek gene

It is generally believed that all things tech are for the boys. We as men, are programmed, it seems, to rip apart gadgets, open up PCs and generally tweak and tinker with everything. It's not just hardware but even software; be it trouble shooting our PCs, fiddling around with Photoshop, dual booting Linux, or spending hours on a tech forum. As it turns out though, all of these things, are not really restricted to men these days and perhaps never were. Think about it - we don't ever hear of female hackers. Is it because there aren't any, or is it because they're just too good to get caught? We've gone on an expedition of sorts



and tried to explore the XX world of geekdom. That's chromosomes you guys!

The female geek is a rather difficult species to identify. Geeky women in reality are nothing like Gretchen Grundler from Recess - soda glasses, braces et al - if that's the first image that came to your mind. They're more like you and I, or just about anybody else. This is also a species that gadget makers are only recently waking up to. A study last year found that out of every ten gadgets bought in the UK, four are

purchased by women. Before your stereotypical mind thinks of mixers, microwaves and toasters, the study meant things like HDTVs, smartphones and gaming consoles. Yes, gaming consoles. Another study noted that in the 25 to 34 age bracket more games are being played by women than men.

So who is our quintessential female geek? We spoke to a lot of women to understand this very question. From those in the online world - tweeps and bloggers to our very own readers - believe it or

not, about 20 percent of those reading this are female. And of course we spoke to a couple of techies. All of our hardcore interrogations yielded a few distinct categories. Take the case of Gursimran Kaur (www.gursimrankaur.com), a quirky Web Designer from Jalandhar. "My morning doesn't begin until I squint my eyes to check my smses, walk over the maze of wires to reach my PC to check my mail", she says. Her work involves the computer and "so most of my better day is spent converting it into a money making machine", she adds. "My only earnest wish is to have my dreams wi-fi enabled so I don't have to waste all those sleeping hours without the internet", she said tongue firmly in cheek. Women have increasingly started living life online. Kanika Sud, one of our readers we spoke to said, "I would love to spend the whole day online if I could". It turns out loads of women in the country are beginning to think the same way. According to comScore data, the total number of women between the age of 15 to 35 logging on to the internet was 52,65,000 in March 2009 and for February 2010 the figure has jumped to 81,01,000 - an increase of 53 % over the past year.

But as it turns out, web obsessed geeks are just the tip of the iceberg. It seems Indian geeky women come in many shapes and err sizes. Some are coders by profession, some are gamer chicks, and some have even leveraged technology to invent some new hardware! More on that later.

Geekism redefined

The fact that Women are taking strides in the IT industry is well known. A survey



I read up on reviews, drink YouTube features and tweet for wisdom whenever I have to invest in a new gadget..

Gursimran Kaur, Freelance Webdesigner and photography enthusiast from Jalandhar



T Bhargavi showing off her Cabtop PC